Diploma in UX Design

Onboarding management

Summary Notes

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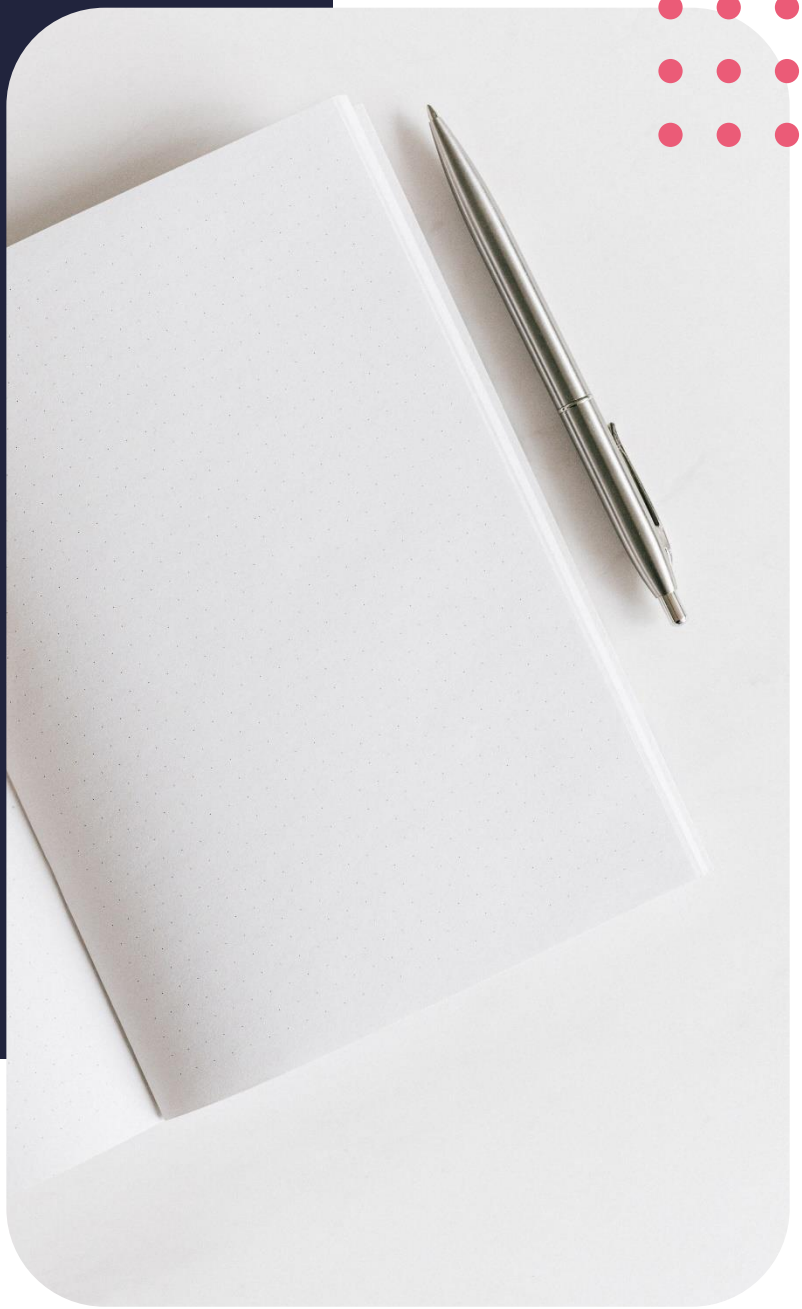

Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Explore the reasons for low app adoption
- Manage onboarding in your organisation
- Create an onboarding checklist

Introduction

There may be several reasons why people don't use your app or getting onboarded successfully. This chapter will investigate some of the most common reasons for poor app adoption and high app drop-off rates. The last part of this lesson will investigate how onboarding can be successfully managed in your organisation.

Reasons for low app adoption

Marketing related reasons for poor app adoption

First, let's look at marketing or awareness related reasons for low app adoption, which is often the most common reason.

1. **Lack of awareness in general or of potential value**

Probably the most common reason for poor adoption of an app or digital product is simply because potential target users don't know it exists, or if they are aware of its existence, they are not aware of the potential value it may bring them or how it could help them easing pain points or reaching goals in an affordable manner. Therefore, use app marketing to promote your app, with persuasive messages to let the user realise the value and ease of use of your product. Address the value for money consideration if high perceived cost is an issue, which is discussed as a separate reason for poor adoption. App marketing is a field on its own and will not be addressed in this course. There are courses out there that address app marketing, but any good course on digital marketing or even marketing in general may help.

2. **Too many alternatives, competition and poor market positioning**

Unless you developed a niche app for a small market or a very new and innovative solution, there are likely to be hundreds if not thousands of alternative solutions already available to your target users.

There are several ways to deal with too much competition. One way may be to improve your app marketing efforts, as discussed above.

Another way in dealing with too much competition may be to differentiate your app so that users can clearly be shown why your app is both different and better than the competitor apps. Competitive strategy is an important aspect of UX design and is usually referred to the field of UX strategy, but any UX designer needs to be aware of basic principles of UX strategy including app competitive strategy. Another lesson will be devoted to UX strategy including competitive strategy. In short, there are four main ways to differentiate your app from competitors. Your app could provide the cheapest or lowest cost solution, or on the other hand it may be the best or most superior solution, or it may be in-between, providing best value as a compromise between cost and quality. The last but broadest option, which is often the best, is to specialise in a very specific niche market or assist users with a very specific need or circumstances.

3. **Lack of motivation to try your app (don't see value or purpose)**

Sometimes a user may be aware of the existence of an app, and know why it is both different and better in comparison to alternative apps, yet the potential user doesn't see sufficient reason to try the app. This is because the person doesn't realise the value that the app will have, or the value may be perceived as not significant enough, or the person may simply not really be your target customer. Or maybe the person is so used to the old way of getting along without the app or doesn't have the time to just sit down and explore your offering.

Often the best way is to use competition and other sales promotion techniques to motivate users to start using digital banking. Make the initial reward something significant, then follow up with less expensive, unpredictable rewards/winnings, until the user becomes fully converted as a regular user. Also pull churning users back with significant rewards.

Another way to motivate potential users to try your app is to make certain it is offered to them the moment that the need for it arises. This is the moment and window of opportunity that the person may be the most motivated to try your app. For example, if you have a dog kennels service or website, use digital marketing techniques that display your adverts to users searching for accommodation or flights, because you know that some of them may need someone to look after their pets while they are away.

Often people are simply not motivated to do anything that isn't a pressing need. They may simply focus on their daily routine and keep postponing or even just thinking that downloading or trying out your app isn't a priority at this point in time, eventually postponing indefinitely. Creating some sort of urgency may help, for example, a limited time offer, or messages making them aware of what they miss out for not making use of your app. Here timing is very important, remind them in the moment that your app would have been most useful.

In low-income countries free data to download and use your app may be a significant boost for app adoption.

User skills or confidence levels as reasons for poor app adoption

1. **Perceived or real lack of basic digital knowledge (too complex)**

Tech laggards, particularly older users, may not have the simplest knowledge to even just download your app. These users may be able to use their phone only to receive or make calls. They may even be able to use a messaging app like WhatsApp. But they may not know how to install, sign up for and use your app. Some users may actually be able to use a variety of the most popular apps but may perceive their digital abilities as insufficient to learn and use any app beyond their comfort zone. To help with adopting your app, simplify processes and conduct user testing, use marketing messages making users aware that it's so easy to use that many people like them, including older or less tech savvy users, easily started using your app.

2. **Difficulty to get help from others**

Sometimes a user just needs some help to get started with your app, from someone who has the patience and capability to teach the user. In case it is an app using sensitive information like a banking or health app, it will be from someone who can be trusted. Having an active, vibrant digital community who can help each other, or good, easy-to understand, concise content like how-to videos or articles and a comprehensive but well organised and concise Questions and Answers section may be very handy. For very complex software, have a list of approved consultants to help the user with installation, training and implementing your solution.

Other times the customer simply cannot be realistically expected to learn to use the app, for example, users with mental or cognitive challenges or of very old age. Possible solutions may include the following:

- Introduce a masquerade functionality into the app where a user can do an in-app call to a call centre agent, who then takes control over of the app, and perform the task on the user's behalf while the user can clearly see what actions are performed and how it is performed. This may be very valuable to teach users to use the app, or to illustrate to users in a transparent manner that the call centre agent is just performing what is needed and therefore can be trusted.

- Introduce account sharing or management capability where a digitally savvy friend or family member can easily help with or perform tasks on behalf of a digitally incapable customer. A good example is a banking app that allows an adult child of an elderly customer to do banking tasks on behalf of his or her elderly parent.
- For the above solutions, introduce functionality where permissions can be set, managed, and monitored by the user so that they can feel in control over who can access what data and functionality on their account. Enable monitoring of activity in the digitally incapable user's account by the user and his/her loved ones, so that several family members, close friends, or guardian can see what the call centre agent or designated account manager are doing and that all is above board.
- Have a concierge service, reception or help desk at your shop or branch entrance in case you have a physical presence. Also have roaming staff member approaching customers in the shop or branch and in other physical channels like ATM eques, randomly asking customers politely what they are here for, then let the assistant immediately set up the user to do it digitally, and again provide the user with a card with instructions as a reminder for how to do it next time.

3. Perceived risk or fear of change

Users who are risk averse, or not open to change or new experiences, may be very reluctant to try out your app. For them, address their common concerns in your marketing messages and your content, especially but not limited to your Frequently Asked Questions section. Also use sales promotion techniques to nudge them to adopt your app. Creating fear for not using your app, and why your app may address those risks, may be very powerful as long as it's sincere and true. Lastly, pre-signup usage, free trials, free low usage tiers or money-back guarantees can be sufficiently convincing.

Poor initial onboarding flow

1. Require sign up before showing sufficient value

A very common reason for poor trial is because potential users are not allowed to explore what the app has to offer before they are required to sign up. Users won't bother signing up if they don't know what they can get from it, they will rather just continue searching for another solution.

Don't require signup or even worse, linking of card details in the beginning of the engagement process. Let the user clearly see and initially experience some signup-free advantages of your offering.

2. Asking too early for payment information or start charging without free trial

If you require payment, it is not recommended to charge or even just ask for card or payment details before you prove to the user that your offering will work for them. At this early stage, users, especially risk averse users, may be too afraid that your offering may not suit their needs or meet their expectations, then they will rather search for an alternative solution than taking a chance on your offering. The only exception is if your app or brand is well known or are backed by leaders in your industry and users know that it is risk free to start paying straight away or that you can be trusted with their banking or credit card information.

3. Complex, effortful, or long sign-up process

The sign-up process must be very quick and easy. Ask only for the minimum information that is really essential at first. Any additional information, even if very handy to you or beneficial to the user, can be progressively asked in future sessions as time goes by and as your relationship with the user grows.

4. Too difficult to figure out how to use

A common reason for poor use of an app is if the user thinks it's difficult to figure out how to start using your app.

- Lack of time or motivation to figure out how to start using your digital channel if you have physical or traditional channels still available: Sometimes users feel that they don't have time to set up your app, especially if you have physical stores or support staff available to them as a traditional alternative. In this case, let your support staff politely and patiently help users to set the app up, sign up for it, and show them how to perform key tasks on it.

Just be aware that helping a customer over and over may point to deeper UX problems. After every session of assistance, tell the customer that they are welcome to be assisted next time again, therefore they must bring their phone again next time if they need help with the tasks that your app provides. This will let customers feel that they are not rudely forced towards digital channels, and it will aid in the user's educational or digital adoption process.

- Too many steps, too little assistance, and encouragement to do the first task successfully: If there are many steps to accomplish something meaningful once signed up, it may be very demotivating to complete the task, therefore the user may never get to the crucial point of experiencing early success. The more steps required, the more complex or effortful the steps are, and the less clear it is what to do at each step. This will discourage the user from continuing. The solution is to simplify processes, especially the most crucial processes to experience initial success, and to conduct thorough user testing to make certain it's easy for your target users to get their important jobs done on your app.
- Lack of encouragement, illustration to do the next task towards goal positive reinforcement: Most users need step-by-step guidance on what to do to accomplish an overall task. Right after signup or logging in, let the user specify what their goal or reason is for being there. Show them clearly how to get there with small, clear steps. After each step has been successfully accomplished, let the user know that they did it successfully. A stepper or progress indicator, possibly with some form of mini celebrations after each successful step, may be very handy.

Losing interest to keep using your app over longer periods

1. **Failure to integrate into life or work tasks through many successful tasks completion**

After your user accomplishes their first goal, which is a crucial milestone, the user must be encouraged to perform a second, third and many more similar tasks. Only after repetitively accomplishing the major tasks or goals, the app will be adopted, because it must become a habit in their normal personal or work life. This can be accomplished by encouraging the user to perform the larger task repetitively, and to explore and perform other major tasks in your app. Praising and positive reinforcement, as discussed next, will also help a lot.

2. **Losing interest and motivation**

A user may quickly get bored with an app. To prevent boredom, provide variable or non-predictive rewards or winnings until using your app becomes a habit, in other words, a part of the user's life. Principles of gamification may also be helpful. Yet another very powerful measure may be to build a community around your app or the need it solves for, so that users can build social ties and interact with each other via your app.

3. **Failure to progressively upgrade user in later or continual onboarding process**

Another very important way to keep users engaged and to increase their lifetime value is to progressively upgrade their skills so that they can use more advanced features. Continuously introduce more powerful features and help them learn those new features so that users can become more productive and accomplish their overall goal easier, faster, and better. This is a key aspect of successful and full customer onboarding.

Poor basic UX as a reason for low app adoption

1. **Poor UX**

A poor user experience is often the main reason for poor app adoption. The obvious solution is to simplify processes and conduct user testing and heuristic evaluations and use other techniques you learn about in this course to streamline and optimise the user experience.

2. **Low cost-benefit ratio of using your solution versus the way the user is used to meet their relevant need**

Maybe using your solution is not worth the effort to solve the user's needs. It could be because another solution is just as easy to use, maybe easier, or because getting along without your solution is not that bad after all. Adopting a new solution is supposed to be perceived as a major improvement to their lives compared to the customers' current way of reaching the intended goal. Your solution must be significantly easier, cheaper, faster or otherwise better. A steep learning curve to use

your product, putting in a lot of effort or paying higher costs, or if it is not perceived to be worth the cost or effort from the user's subjective perspective, will deter adoption of your app. Therefore, it is essential to make certain that your app meets a real and significant user need and that it is a better solution than the status quo. It is also important to communicate this clearly to your target users in your marketing messages.

3. **Lack of personal, face-to-face, interactive communication and immediate feedback or answers**

A major reason why many customers prefer visits to traditional channels such as stores or branches instead of an app, is because they want to be able to 'speak to a real person'. This can be compensated for by incorporating a live chat functionality onto the app or using a popular messenger service such as WhatsApp as a supplementary communication channel, and a 'please call me back' button with scheduling option where a user can schedule a time or select 'as soon as possible'.

4. **Poor inclusivity**

It is very important to design for inclusivity to encourage adoption of your app. There are various forms and various degrees of disability or other forms of exclusion. Amongst the highest priority types of inclusiveness that needs to be addressed to increase app adoption include:

- Poor literacy. Use ample, meaningful icons, short, simple sentences, ample illustrations/animations and enable users to use your app in their own language. Also experiment with voice-enabled banking. This can also be very important to attract late tech adopters.
- Poor digital savviness. Take your USSD offering very seriously and use a flat information architecture for your app with very intuitive icons and descriptive labels.
- Poor eyesight. Use excellent legibility, sufficient but non-clashing contrast, non-script font, and larger font size.

Rural or low-income user segments' reasons for poor app adoption

The following may be reasons for poor app adoption in low-income countries or amongst customer segments with low income, or in deep rural areas with poor internet connectivity:

1. **Lack of connectivity**

Poor connectivity is a major reason for poor adoption in many rural, sparsely populated, or underdeveloped areas. Users may not have any connectivity at all and must make use of online services if they travel to a nearby town or major road. However, more often users have some connectivity, but it is unpredictable, sometimes on and sometimes off, or of poor strength. This is where apps with good offline and low connectivity capabilities have a huge competitive advantage. There are ways to develop an app to handle such offline or poor connectivity circumstances using cashing strategies and other methods that your developer can advise you about.

Another way to deal with poor connectivity is to not only have an app or website, but also have a USSD service. Maintain and promote your USSD service in areas where connectivity is better with USSD compared to data which is required for apps and websites. Therefore, in areas with good GSM or USSD coverage but poor data or 3G, 4G or 5G coverage, focus digital adoption and marketing activities on the promotion of USSD, not on your App or internet offering.

Although using USSD code is acceptable to some users and often preferred by digitally less-savvy users, it does not provide the convenience and richness of interaction of an app or website. If significant areas or populations within your target market area are still only served with USSD coverage but not yet 3G or newer coverage, consider adding functionality to the app to use USSD rather than internet protocol in the background for backend communication but still using the same app interface as for normal data. This can be implemented by developer's code that first tries to make an HTTPS call from the app to the backend, and if it fails or rather if connectivity is detected as poor, USSD protocol with the appropriate code can be automatically called. This will save the user from learning USSD codes and enjoy the app while under the hood the app still makes use of old communication technologies, making relevant USSD calls on user's behalf with the press of a button. Of course, it will only be of use to users with smartphones, not with older feature phones, but in many parts of the world this can be a significant size of the population.

2. **Poor access to devices**

In low-income regions or user segments, not many users own a smartphone, and if they do, ownership is often interrupted by periods of repair or while waiting to be replaced after theft, loss or being broken or if borrowed to a family member or friend.

One way to deal with this problem is to help customers finance a basic, low-cost device. If you work for a large company who has a strong collective bargaining power, you will be able to negotiate a lower price because you can buy in bulk. This option is especially viable in case you are likely to capture a lot of profit from the customer, for example, if you are a bank or a cellular phone company.

Enable device sharing with quick, simple logging in and out of the app/internet banking or user switching for USSD, so that several users can do banking on the same device. Very much like Gmail allows several account holders to access mail from the same device by logging in and out. Make user switching very easy, quick, and secure, and make it clear to the user that they are properly logged out of a session when done. This will address device access to a large degree because many users don't have a device but have a close friend or family member who does. Do not underestimate USSD but treat it as a valued channel. Many digital laggards only have feature phones, not smartphones, therefore if a full service, as opposed to just a few functionalities, are provided via USSD, and if the UX of using USSD is optimised, digital adoption will increase.

3. Expensive data costs

For a large proportion of customers, the real or perceived data cost of downloading, updating, and using the app is too expensive. This can be a major reason for poor app adoption in low-income countries, amongst low-income customers and especially where data costs are high.

One way to manage expensive data is to arrange with telecommunication companies or cellular network providers to pay for the data that your app uses and using sales promotion tactics to provide data bundles to your users. However, if you do this, many users may not be aware, therefore what you pay for needs to be clearly communicated in your marketing messages.

Another very effective way to deal with high data costs is to have a USSD service to complement your app, specifically aimed at lower income or more price sensitive customers. USSD does not require the large data quantities associated with modern apps.

Yet another way to deal with high data costs is to minimise initial app download size as well as data consumption during continuous use. This may be particularly effective. Ask your developer team about these options, including the use of modern frontend frameworks and app caching strategies.

Did you know?

Did you know that more than half of users will not visit your product if it is not mobile-friendly? Users nowadays are more on their phones than computers, so it is essential that you consider the responsiveness of your website for mobile devices as a top priority.

Managing onboarding in your organisation

Onboarding is a crucial part of the User Experience and must receive the necessary resources and commitment from management. The following can be implemented to ensure that onboarding is properly managed:

1. Prioritising and recognising the importance of onboarding

Prioritise the design of an efficient onboarding programme that provides value as soon as possible with minimal user effort. Onboarding must be appreciated as a crucial activity by senior management, and sufficient resources must be allocated.

2. Have a cross-functional team

The onboarding task does not only lay with the User Experience team. Senior management, marketing, sales, customer success, innovation and developer teams must also be closely involved. A seamless onboarding process necessitates much more teams than only the product manager's team to be involved, but also the various other teams mentioned above.

3. Develop a clear, common vision for onboarding

It's essential to have a clear and common vision for onboarding and adoption of your app. Everyone involved must have a common understanding of the problem, scope and solutions, and agreement on the goals. This can be achieved through regular reimagination sessions between the members in the interdisciplinary team, and user co-creation sessions with users involved, where the user's onboarding journey can be constantly improved.

4. Identify and track quantifiable onboarding success indicators and goals

The only way to know if your onboarding process is working and improving over time is to measure key indicators of onboarding success. The most important indicators should be designed around:

- Growth in visitor numbers and bounce rate on landing page(s) or home page of website. This may point to SEO and content issues.
- Decrease in percentage of users who abandoned the signup process. This may point to improved motivation and successful simplification of the early stages of the signup process.
- Increase in successful signup of new users. This may point to improved motivation, initial engagement, and successful simplification of later stages in the signup process.
- Reduction of churn rate of single use users. Many users sign up but never return, which points to very specific onboarding strategies that can be improved.
- Reduction of the churn rate of users who successfully used your app for some time. This points to issues related to poor initial engagement and poor user experience.
- Introduction of new features and means to engage users. This may point to the success of the innovation process.
- Uptake of new features. This may point to issues in the later onboarding process.
- Uptake in the referral programme. Refer-a-friend incentives may be very valuable to encourage digital adoption amongst late adopters.
- Uptake of sales promotion or loyalty initiatives. This may point to opportunities to improve user engagement.
- In case your organisation had a traditional bricks-and-mortar infrastructure of retail outlets, shops or branches and you wish to shift customers to your digital channels, key performance indicators such as number of users educated at shop level about and using your app, new digital sign ups of existing customers, percentage of existing customers using the app, may be important to track. Another important indicator may be the reduction of customers visiting your branches but be aware to take into consideration the growing importance of omnichannel retail, which is the preference of many customers to use a mix of online and physical channels along their

customer journey, and that it should not reflect a loss of market share. Omnichannel interactions such as QR scanning at your shops, usage of geo-payments may also be important.

5. Have a single team and person leading and responsible for onboarding

Although it is essential to have a cross-functional team, there should be a responsible person for making final decisions and being responsible for the onboarding programme. This will make execution of strategy easier, more responsive and agile and make it possible to have someone accountable for reaching onboarding goals. If no one owns it, interventions to drive digital adoption will be slow and onboarding may fail, eventually causing the whole product to fail.

Onboarding checklist

With all the onboarding information that you've learned in the last two lessons, it is very easy to get lost in this vast sea of information. An onboarding checklist will assist you in getting the grips on this process. User onboarding forms the backbone of any UX design and therefore it is essential for you to get the grips on this.

The good news is that there are a variety of tools you can utilise that will assist you in the onboarding process. One such tool is called User Guiding and you can access it easily via any web browser.

As you've learnt in the last two lessons, one of the main reasons why users abandon a digital product is due to a lack of understanding and frustration. Due to the variety of products and target audiences you will be dealing with, your onboarding process might differ quite a bit and therefore needs to be personalised. Checklists are one of the more common and effective onboarding tools and I will share some crucial aspects you can consider when you set up a user onboarding checklist.

A user onboarding checklist is a list of tasks your user will need to complete during the onboarding stage. The question you probably still have is how and where do I start to create such a checklist? With a tool like User Guiding, you can create a checklist to fit your personal digital product.

First, you need to have some information about your digital product before starting.

It is essential that you identify your value metric, which is when your user understands and appreciate the value of your product, secondly, you will need to map out the steps your user will take to get there. Lastly, make sure that you view this product from your user's perspective.

You will soon realise that when you create an account using a tool like UserGuiding, you will most likely follow the same process as your potential users, so pay close attention when you create an account or sign up to any new digital product in future.

For this lesson's challenge, I want you to create a UserGuiding account and make use of the features to create a user onboarding checklist. If you do not have any digital product in mind, let's use the scenario of creating a digital product that allows users the opportunity to get groceries delivered to their desired address. You are more than welcome to do research on existing apps and tools with similar functionality and apply and improve that in your version.

Lesson challenge

For this lesson's challenge, I want you to create a UserGuiding account and make use of the features to create a user onboarding checklist. If you do not have any digital product in mind, let's use the scenario of creating a digital product that allows users the opportunity to get groceries delivered to their desired address. You are more than welcome to do research on existing apps and tools with similar functionality and apply and improve that in your version.

Conclusion

In this lesson we learned why users typically not get onboarded successfully, and how comprehensive and systematic onboarding best practices can be used to increase adoption of your app. We've also learned how important it is to take onboarding seriously in an organisation, and how it can be managed to achieve digital product success.

Brenda Lauren is a video game designer and researcher. She states that using a design is the ultimate goal of any UX project. What is the use if your digital product or app looks amazing but can't be utilised?

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